Sublime irony

The American nuclear strategist Herman Kahn once offered a thousand dollars to anyone who could provide a plausible scenario of how nuclear war between the USA and the USSR might happen.[15] Many historians of the Cuban missile crisis would now see this as easy money. Kahn's assumption was that as political leaders were sufficiently rational to understand that nuclear war meant mutual annihilation, they would never fight one. A similar logic underpinned the agreement between Mikhail Gorbachev and Ronald Reagan, at their summit in Geneva in June 1985, that: 'a nuclear war cannot be won and must never be fought.'[16] Others spelt out the logic of mutual deterrence. Writing in 1953, 'the father of the atomic bomb,' Robert Oppenheimer, suggested that:

> We may anticipate a state of affairs in which two Great Powers will each be in a position to put an end to the civilization and life of the other. We may be likened to two scorpions in a bottle each capable of killing the other, but only at the risk of his own life. [17]

Neither could strike first, lest they suffer retaliatory annihilation, but both needed to threaten annihilation, lest the adversary strike without fear of their own destruction. The logic was eloquently expressed in 1955 by Prime Minister Winston Churchill, who told the House of Commons that the advent of thermonuclear weapons (or hydrogen bombs as they were popularly known), meant that by 'a process of sublime irony… safety will be the sturdy child of terror, and survival the twin brother of annihilation.'[18] The hydrogen bomb, he averred, was the 'the Second Coming in Wrath.'

Churchill, it might be noted, had a personal interest in the Day of Judgement. Under the terms of the 1943 Quebec agreement between Churchill and Roosevelt, it was agreed that the bomb was not to be used against 'third parties without each other's consent,' providing in theory a British veto on its use.[19] Winston Churchill gave his consent (although Clement Attlee was Prime Minister when the bombs were dropped). After the war, Winston mused that this was perhaps the only decision for which